FESTIVAL

Maximum *Cinema*

The Mumbai Film Festival is back after a pandemic-induced hiatus

Early this year, Priyanka Chopra Jonas hosted a pre-Oscars bash in Hollywood to celebrate South Asian talent both on and behind the screen. A few days later, Indian films *RRR* (2022) and *The Elephant Whisperers* (2022) won at the Oscars. South Asia will be the focus again this time at the Jio MAMI Mumbai Film Festival (October 27 to November 5), of which Chopra is the chairperson. Returning after a pandemic-induced intermission of three years, the festival will host 130 filmmakers and screen 250 films across 20 venues around Mumbai. One of them is the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre's 2,000-seater Grand Theatre, where Chopra is expected to host an opening gala.

"We were sure if MAMI is to be back in Mumbai, it has to be in a bigger way and with a newer vision," says artistic director Deepti DCunha, who has worked with international film festivals as a programmer and has been part of the NFDC's (National Film Development Corporation) Film Bazaar. Spotlighting South Asian films is a cause dear to DCunha. "Literature, art and academia have been talking about South Asian as



"Literature, art and academia have been talking about South Asian as an identity for quite some time. We're just bringing it into cinema", says MAMI artistic director Deepti DCunha



A still from *Maestro*